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I Need Wheels

Certainly there are lots of things in life that money won't buy, but it's funny — have you ever tried to buy them without money?

—Ogden Nash

Buying a car is usually the first major purchase for a young adult and it is often the second largest monthly expense after your housing payment (unless you live with your parents). In Merrill Lynch's third annual teen survey, 30 percent of the teens polled said that they were saving money in order to buy a car. Among the top plans for money being saved by teens, a car was second only to a college education.

To a teen, a car is more than just a set of wheels, an engine, and a metal body; it is a sign of freedom. It is the chance to be free from parental supervision and avoid having to be chauffeured around anymore. Once a teen begins working, the car becomes a necessity, a way to get to and from a job. And for a young adult, a car can be a sign of success. It can send a message to their friends, colleagues, and dates, "The nicer the car, the more successful the owner."

However, purchasing a car is often confusing for an experienced adult. Imagine how difficult it is for a first-time car buyer. Many decisions must be made on the spot, such as: should I buy a new car or a used one; should I lease the car or